THE MUMBAI POLICE'S IMAGE TOOK A BEATING WHEN ONE OF ITS OFFICERS, SACHIN VAZE, WAS FOUND INVOLVED IN THE PLANTING OF AN EXPLOSIVES-LADEN SUV NEAR MUKESH AMBANI'S HOME IN MUMBAI ON FEBRUARY 26 LAST YEAR. THE SUV'S OWNER, MANSUKH HIRAN, WAS THEN FOUND MURDERED. THE CASE HAS SINCE GOT MURKIER, WITH THE PROBE EXPANDING INTO ALLEGED MONEY-LAUNDERING AND EVEN A POLICE POSTINGS RACKET. THE TWISTS AND TURNS CONTINUE...

BY KIRAN D. TARE



ANIL PARAB
MAHARASHTRA TRANSPORT MINISTER

The Uddhav Thackeray loyalist is at the centre of a controversy over postings of Maharashtra police officers.

THE CHARGES: On February 3, Anil Deshmukh told ED officials that Parab had provided him unofficial lists of transfer of police officers, which were allegedly forwarded to the additional chief secretary (home) for discussions with the Police Establishment Board. Vaze has told the ED that Parab and Deshmukh had taken Rs 20 crore each for revoking transfers of 10 DCPs made by Param Bir Singh.

HIS DEFENCE: Denying sending any list to Deshmukh, Parab says police transfers are handled by the home department.

LEGAL POSITION: The Chandiwal Commission may summon Parab to record his statement pertaining to the postings of police officers.

THE STATUS: Parab, despite the controversy, continues to enjoy Uddhav's confidence.



ANI

SACHIN VAZE
DISMISSED ASSISTANT POLICE INSPECTOR

The controversial officer was arrested by the NIA (National Investigation Agency) on March 13, 2021 for allegedly planting explosives near Ambani's home and the murder of Thane businessman Mansukh Hiran. As head of the Mumbai police CIU, he had led investigations in sensational cases, such as actor Sushant Singh Rajput's death in June 2020 and the TRP scam later that year. He was dismissed on May 11, 2021. Vaze had joined the Shiv Sena in 2008, but the party claims his membership was not renewed after 2010.

THE CHARGES: An NIA chargesheet in September 2021 states that Vaze wanted to regain his clout as an ace detective/ encounter specialist, following a 16-year suspension in a custodial death case. Vaze, the chargesheet states, conspired to plant the explosives and threat note for Ambani, and was also involved in the murder of Hiran, a key witness.

HIS DEFENCE: Vaze has done several flip-flops on the extortion allegations against Deshmukh. In December 2021, he told the Chandiwal Commission that Deshmukh never asked him to extort bar/ restaurant owners. In a U-turn on February 8, he claimed he had extorted and personally delivered the money to Deshmukh, and also filed an application with the commission to retract his previous statement. "I handed over the cash to people associated with Anil Deshmukh, upon his instructions," he stated.

LEGAL POSITION: The Chandiwal Commission has rejected Vaze's application, suspecting ulterior motives.

THE STATUS: Vaze is lodged in Taloja Central Jail in Navi Mumbai.